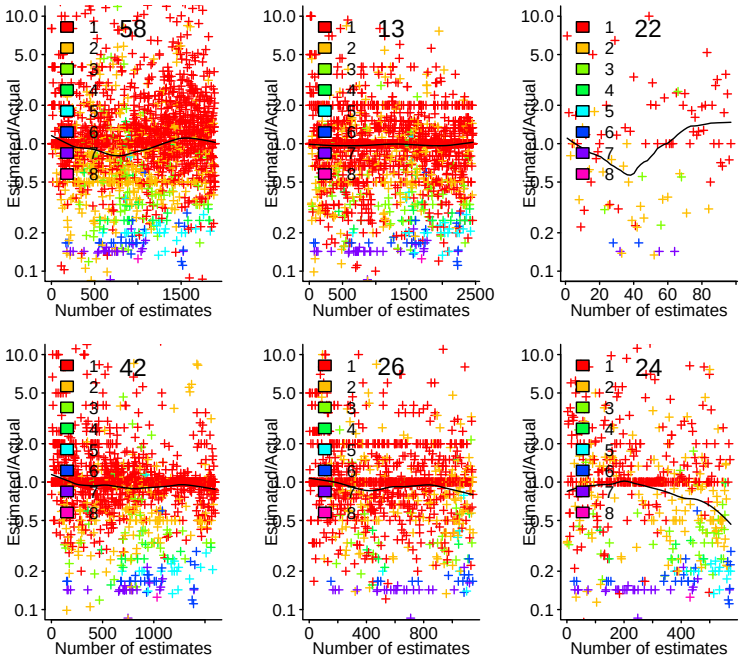


Figure 5: Accuracy of estimates made by some developers.

calls or emails or any other non-chargeable Task you can think of. If it came in late, then the additional time was generally found by pushing back work outside of the release or taking the work home with you.

If the Tasks agreed for the release were completed by the deadline, then everyone was happy. This meant that under estimated work was bad but accurate and over estimates were deemed OK, i.e., we hit the target or came in earlier (and cheaper). We reported Tasks to the client not hours because that is what they cared about. This meant we thought of Tasks in terms of accurate, under and over estimates, rather than hours, minutes and seconds.

Carrying out a very crude timeline analysis of `COMPLETED` and `FINISHED` Development Tasks across all SiP staff shows some interesting behaviour.

In the heaviest development times (first 5-years) over and under estimates flip flopped, which lead to improved accuracy. After the first 5-years when the majority of development tailed off into the support phase, work volume dropped but interestingly so did the focus on accuracy, with over estimating taking precedence. I am assuming we became more aware of the political benefits of under promising, whilst over delivering.

Taking two active developers, say 13 and 26 this pattern repeats (see Figure 6).

Accuracy improves over time, especially in heavy development phases (2005-2008), but as supporting the product becomes the key activity, accuracy loses its